



Harmony, Respect, Purity and Tranquility and is unique to Japan. Hotels and gardens offer Tea Ceremony open to the public and a visit to Japan should include this on the itinerary.

APRIL

Tokyo is covered in a pelt of luscious pink in April. The Cherry Blossom season is one of the most cherished times and people gather for lively picnic parties under the spreading branches. Night Sakura can be serene and mystical with the pale pink trees awash in light against the deep night sky. Nothing can compare to a cup of warm rice wine under a blooming Sakura tree.

MAY

During May, Tokyo overflows with flowering trees and fauna. The perfume of Jasmine and Gardenia will greet you as you stroll along any street and the myriad colors of the Camellia grown throughout the city are a photographer's dream. Taking a ride on a Yakatabune would also be a nice way to enjoy a lazy May evening. Yakatabune are long boats with roofs that seat up to 100 people. Beginning in the Heian period around 798, Yakatabune features traditional Japanese food like Tempura, boiled vegetables and sashimi (raw fish) with the back drop of the city's bright on-shore lights.

JUNE

With June comes Tsuyu or the rainy season. Rain during this time of year is often less stormy and more of a sweet, light drizzle. This is the time to escape to places like Yugawara (in the mountains outside of Tokyo) and enjoy a traditional Japanese Ryokan (hot spring inn). Being a volcanic island, Japan has an endless amount of hot spring and the minerals in the naturally heated water are both relaxing and healing. Ryokan have meticulously landscaped and cared-for hot baths that are separate for men and women as well as special hot springs that can be reserved for family use. After relaxing in the healing waters of the hot spring, visitors don a traditional Yukata robe and dine on delicious Japanese cuisine.

JULY

Japan's humid Summer starts in July. The Chiba coast about 2 hours by train from Tokyo offers clean sand and pristine water. Beginner surfers can also enjoy the gentle waves of the Pacific during this time of year. Most public beaches are carefully monitored by lifeguards and bungalows along the beach offer shade, food, showers and lounge areas at reasonable rates.